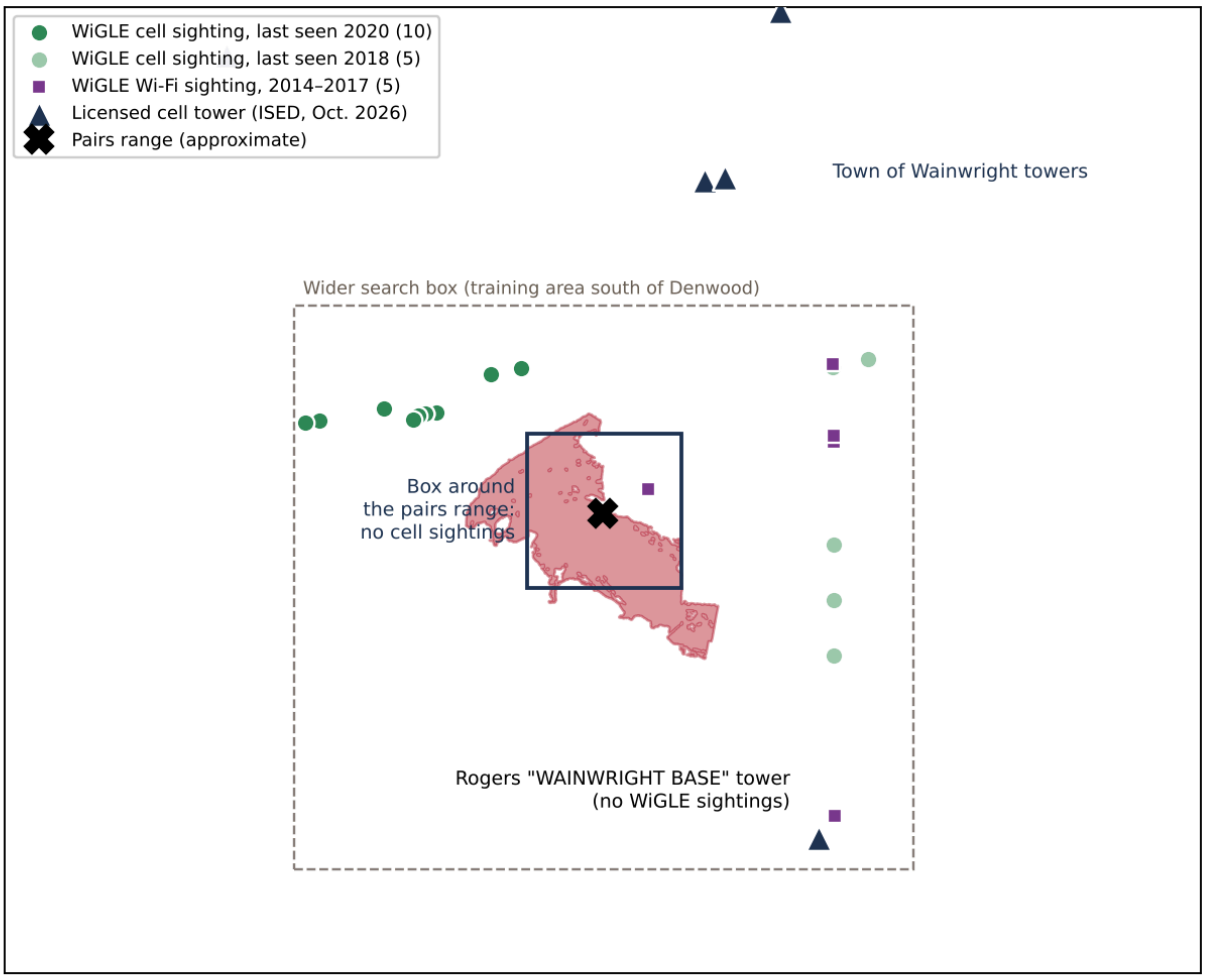
Was there phone signal on the range? What crowdsourced network data can and can't tell us

Kevin J.S. Duska Jr. · Oct. 29, 2026

If radios failed or nets were busy on the afternoon of Oct. 17, a phone could have been the fallback for the soldiers on the pairs range. I checked WiGLE, the crowdsourced database of Wi-Fi and cell networks logged by contributors' phones, for any sign of cell coverage near where the fire reached the troops. I'm a WiGLE contributor, and I ran the searches through my own account.

Bottom line

- **No one has ever logged a cell signal in the immediate area.** In a box about 3 km across, centred on the pairs range, WiGLE has no cell sightings at all.
- **Phones have connected nearby, but not recently.** Across the wider training area south of Denwood there are 15 cell sightings: TELUS 4G (LTE) and older networks 3.6 to 6.7 km to the west-northwest, and TELUS and Bell along a road 5 to 7 km east. The newest is from July 2020.
- **The nearest tower doesn't appear at all.** Rogers holds a licence for a tower named "WAINWRIGHT BASE", 8.5 km from the pairs range. No WiGLE contributor has ever logged it in this area.
- **So this can't settle the question.** The data suggests phones could pick up a signal within a few kilometres of the range, but it's six years old and nothing was logged at the site. It neither confirms nor rules out coverage on Oct. 17.



Data: WiGLE.net (crowdsourced; positions are where devices heard a network, not tower locations); ISED licence data. Burn outline and analysis: Prime Rogue Inc.

WiGLE sightings around the Oct. 17 burn, with the cell towers licensed today. A WiGLE dot marks where a contributor's phone heard a network, not where the tower stands.

What I found

Where	What WiGLE has	When last seen
Box about 3 km across, centred on the pairs range	No cell sightings. One Wi-Fi network about 1.1 km away, probably a portable hotspot	Early 2017
3.6–6.7 km west-northwest of the pairs range	10 TELUS cell sightings, mostly LTE (4G) and GSM	2020 (Feb.–Jul.)
5–8 km east, along a north–south road	4 TELUS cell sightings and 1 Bell; 4 Wi-Fi networks	2014–2018
Rogers "WAINWRIGHT BASE" tower, 8.5 km away	No sightings of Rogers in the area	n/a

Why the gaps matter

WiGLE depends on people carrying phones running its app. The Wainwright training area is closed to the public, so almost everything logged inside it came from the few people who happened to run the app while there. An empty patch on the map means nobody logged anything, not that there was no signal.

The most recent sighting is from 2020. Networks in rural Alberta have changed a lot since then. The Rogers tower nearest the range, licensed today with low-band 4G and 5G that travel a long way, may simply be newer than any sighting.

Phone coverage on Oct. 17 can only be established another way: a coverage model built from the licensed towers and the terrain (which I'm working on), the carriers' own coverage records, or DND and the soldiers themselves.

What I left out

WiGLE records the names of Wi-Fi networks. I haven't recorded or published any of them, including any that might belong to the base, because they add nothing to the coverage question. This report uses only network type, carrier, location and date.

Method and limits

I searched WiGLE on Oct. 29, 2026, through my contributor account, using two boxes. The first runs 52.755–52.785 N and 110.925–110.875 W (about 3 km around the pairs range). The second covers the training area south of Denwood, 52.70–52.81 N and 111.00–110.80 W. Each search covered both cell and Wi-Fi sightings. WiGLE positions are estimated from the contributors who logged each network, so they show where a network was heard, not where its transmitter is. Cell tower locations are from ISED's licence data, dated Oct. 5, 2026. The pairs-range location is approximate.

Sources

- WiGLE.net, crowdsourced wireless network database (searched Oct. 29, 2026)
- ISED, Spectrum Management System data downloads (cell site data, Oct. 5, 2026)

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